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TOP STORY

Kootenai County Sheriff's Office to lose license plate reader technology due to budget constraints

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Showing



COEUR D'ALENE, Idaho — The Kootenai County Sheriff's Office will lose automatic license plate reader technology after commissioners decided not to renew the \$24,000 annual contract.

All across Kootenai County, the sheriff's office has used the technology to monitor roads and track criminals. The automatic license plate readers have been deployed across the department's fleet for seven months.

"What it does is it monitors all the license plates that drive past the patrol cars," said Lieutenant Mark Ellis of the Kootenai County Sheriff's Office.

The sheriff's office says the technology has helped track down wanted criminals, including major cases that extend beyond county lines.

"One was a homicide suspect out of Montana that we were able to actually flag with one of our patrol cars. We were able to make a traffic stop with it and arrest the homicide suspect and take them into custody," Ellis said.

The technology also helps keep deputies safe by automatically scanning license plates of cars they pull over, letting deputies know what kind of situation they may be walking into.

"Automatically what happens is our dispatcher can see that, the other deputy can see it. And without even having to request additional help, we can get them in route," Ellis said.

In the seven months the sheriff's office has used the technology, officials feel it has been successful.

"We have had some pretty significant finds," Ellis said.

The system has also benefited regional law enforcement cooperation.

"It's great because, several of the cases we've had, we've actually worked with Spokane, where their cameras picked up some of the suspects. Our cameras pick up some of the suspects, and we're actually able to connect those two," Ellis said.

However, the Board of County Commissioners says the results are not significant enough to justify the \$24,000 cost. Some constituents also oppose the technology.

"We've had a town hall and I get calls and emails from constituents quite often. They just don't like the idea of the mobile license plate reader," said Commissioner Leslie Duncan.

Duncan says the money would be better used elsewhere.

"We do have higher priorities, like cost of living adjustments and wages, wage increases for the county and the sheriff's department," Duncan said.

Despite the sheriff's office arguing the technology benefits not only Kootenai County but the entire region, the technology will only be available until the end of 2025. After that, the sheriff's office says this will be a step back in its capabilities.

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